private jetties.[70] There was a crane to lift upto five tons and six other cranes on the iron jetty, each with a capacity to lift ¾ tons.[71]

As noted earlier, large vessels anchored in the roadstead at Hare Island about 8 km from Tuticorin. Vessels were loaded and discharged by means of large cargo boats while smaller boats and launches transported passengers. By the time of our story, a proper steam launch was indispensable for this function.

Connected by rail by 1875, Tuticorin became the terminus of the South Indian Railway (SIR). With this, the port was linked to Madurai in the north, to Tirunelveli and to the princely state of Travancore in the west. In 1899, the main line was extended to the quay for easy transfer of cargo to the steamers. The railroad gave a major impetus to the trade of Tuticorin. The trains trundled alongside the landing and shipping wharves enabling the easy transfer of passengers and cargo to the launches that took them to the anchored ships—a process that took about forty-five minutes.[72]

By the late nineteenth century, the chief exports from Tuticorin, apart from cotton, were rice, pulses, palmyra jaggery, coffee, cinchona, senna, cardamom, chillies, onions, fibre, mustard, coriander, fodder, dried fish, oil-cake and hides and skin. Boasting of many salt pans, the production and export of salt increased with the integration to the rail network. Imports included piece goods, hardware, spirits, grains, timber, cattle, sheep and poultry. Goats and sheep were also traded and often as many as 600 animals would be transported on a voyage.[73] During the protests of 1908, when the town was tense and the local butchers stopped serving Europeans, the latter relied on meat from Colombo. Rules—more often than not breached—stipulated that the passengers should not be inconvenienced by cattle, and that they should be penned separately.[74]

If this was the cargo story, what about human migration? By 1911, the Indian Tamil population in Ceylon—overwhelmingly in the upcountry plantations—numbered over 5,30,000. Plantation workers came from Thanjavur, Tiruchirappalli, North and South Arcot, Madurai and Ramnad districts apart from the princely state of Pudukkottai. The migration of those